

effluent treatment systems, water management infrastructure and energy-efficient engineering systems supporting a zero-wastewater-discharge objective. "These were incorporated into the design itself rather than added later through isolated interventions," says Medical Director Dr Sanjeev Singh. "For many hospitals, sustainability is still a facilities management topic. Globally, however, it is beginning to shape how hospitals are designed and operated over the long term."

Apollo has formalised this shift through a three-band tiering system for retrofits and newer greenfield projects built to IGBC (Indian Green Building Council) and GRIHA standards. GRIHA norms are national green building standards developed by TERI and endorsed by the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy.

124 | Fortis, meanwhile, has developed a methodology that measures energy and water consumption per occupied bed rather than in absolute terms, linking environmental impact directly to clinical activity levels. The company says the framework helps compare sustainability performance across facilities and identify areas with high energy and water usage.

THE WASTE PROBLEM

If energy is the most tractable sustainability challenge for hospitals, waste is the most visible. Since the pandemic exposed the scale of single-use plastics, consumables and biomedical material generated by healthcare facilities, waste management has come under scrutiny.

"Biomedical waste management has become one of the most watched areas in healthcare operations," says Dr Singh. "Today, biomedical waste is not just about systems, but also about behavioural discipline across the institution."

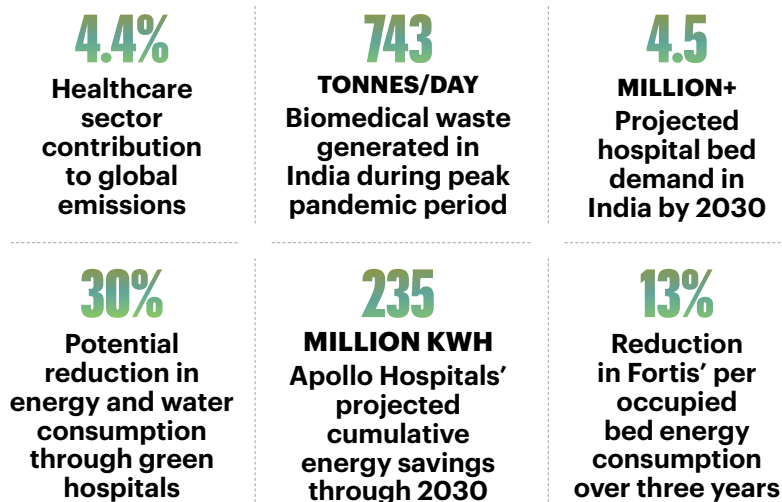
The Biomedical Waste Management Rules 2016 and CPCB guidelines have progressively tightened accountability. Apollo operates colour-coded segregation protocols across facilities, with biomedical waste handled through State Pollution Control Board-authorised treatment facilities. The group's shift from conventional HDPE plastic bags to biodegradable cornstarch alternatives has removed around 200,000 kg conventional plastic from its waste stream.

Apollo's FY24 disclosures show waste generated fell by 200 metric tonnes compared to FY23.

Fortis follows a similar compliance structure and reports biomedical waste quantities to the Central Pollution Control Board. The company says its facilities conduct periodic staff trainings on waste segregation and disposal protocols.

Hospitals are also using technology to improve monitoring and resource utilisation. Digital systems

THE BIG CHALLENGE



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THE SUSTAINABILITY PRESSURE

- Rising biomedical waste volumes
- Higher electricity and water consumption across large hospital campuses
- Expansion of private hospitals into Tier-II and Tier-III cities
- SEBI's mandatory BRSR disclosure framework for listed companies
- Growing scrutiny from investors, lenders and global healthcare partners
- Pressure to reduce operating costs without affecting affordability